



The Best Places to Eat Patatnik

Alexandrovi Kushti inexpensive

Located in Zlatograd's old Museum Quarter, Alexandrovi Kushti occupies a wonderfully restored 19th-century building with a wood-paneled interior featuring ornate carvings by local craftsmen. As you'd expect from a restaurant that has published its own cookbook of regional delights, the *patatnik* here is superb – cooked slowly over a stove and turned midway through, as the crust develops, according to the traditional recipe.

Bulgarian cuisine is renowned for its broad variety of salads and this is also a great place to sample a classic *shopska* salad of tomatoes, cucumbers, onion, and white cheese accompanied by a complimentary glass of *rakia*. Carnivores can choose from a staggering array of meat dishes that range from fried chicken hearts to a whole baked lamb; vegetarians are equally well catered to, with enticing options such as *chushky burek* (stuffed peppers) and *sarmi* (vine leaves filled with rice). Save room for a dessert of sticky baklava or sweet *banitsa* filled with Turkish delight and sit back to enjoy a live performance of Bulgarian folk music.

Museum Quarter, Zlatograd; open for lunch and dinner daily; +359 3071 4166

Also in the Rhodope Mountains

Patatnik, *klin*, roast lamb, and sweet *banitsa* are among the specialties served up at **Mehana Pri Slavchev (+359 3030 675; inexpensive)**. This traditional *mehana* is in Shiroka Luka, a pretty village of sturdy stone houses famous for its annual bagpipe festival. In Smolyan, **Trite Eli (+359 301 81028; inexpensive)**, also known as Three Fir-Tree House, is run by a wonderfully hospitable English-speaking tour guide. This small *pension* has a tiny dining room where guests are served a mind-boggling array of mouthwatering Rhodopean dishes, cooked by the owner using the freshest of ingredients.

Also in Bulgaria

Hidden deep within Sofia's densely forested Borisova Garden, **Veselo Selo (www.veseloselo.com; moderate)** is one of the few places that serves *patatnik* in Sofia. The enchanting restaurant complex resembles a country *mehana* – once inside, it's easy to forget that you're close to the heart of the capital.

Around the World

One of several Bulgarian restaurants in London, **Arda 2 (+44 20 7263 5902; moderate)** serves all manner of traditional dishes and, although it doesn't specialize in Rhodopean cuisine, the chef will accept advance orders for *patatnik*. Live folk performances add extra flavor.